

When Blessings Become a Curse

Prosperity, Persecution, and the Danger of Forgetting God

There is something deeply paradoxical about the Christian life. We naturally assume that hardship is the great enemy of faith and prosperity is its friend. We pray for peace, security, abundance, and freedom from persecution—and rightly so. Yet Scripture repeatedly presents another side of the story: adversity can strengthen faith, while prosperity can quietly weaken it.

The problem is not prosperity itself. God blessed many faithful people in Scripture with material abundance. Nor is suffering automatically virtuous. The Bible never teaches us to seek persecution or hardship for their own sake. Rather, Scripture reveals that both adversity and prosperity can test the human heart.

Hardship can drive us toward God because it exposes our weakness.

Prosperity can draw us away from God because it can convince us that we no longer need Him.

God's blessings become a curse when we love the gift more than the Giver, trust the provision more than the Provider, and depend upon our prosperity more than we depend upon God.

That principle runs throughout Scripture, and perhaps nowhere is it more clearly demonstrated than in the history of Israel.

The Wilderness Taught Israel Dependence

Before Israel entered the Promised Land, God took them through a wilderness.

The wilderness was not a place of abundance. There were no comfortable houses, cultivated fields, abundant possessions, or reliable human resources. Israel had to depend upon God for food, water, protection, direction, and ultimately their very survival.

Yet Moses explained that the wilderness had a purpose:

“And you shall remember the whole way that the LORD your God has led you these forty years in the wilderness, that he might humble you and test you, to know what was in your heart.”

—Deuteronomy 8:2

The wilderness revealed what was in their hearts.

Every morning reminded Israel that they needed God's provision. Every day they had to follow His direction. Their circumstances continually reminded them that they were dependent upon Him.

There is something spiritually healthy about recognizing that we need God.

The wilderness taught Israel that lesson.

But Moses knew another test was coming.

The Danger Was Waiting in the Promised Land

One might think Israel's greatest danger would be the wilderness. Moses apparently understood that another danger could be even greater.

It was prosperity.

He warned them:

“When you have eaten and are full, and have built good houses and live in them... and your silver and your gold is multiplied, and all that you have is multiplied, then your heart be lifted up, and you forget the LORD your God.”

—Deuteronomy 8:12–14

When Israel was hungry, they cried out to God. When they were surrounded by enemies, they cried out to God. When they were oppressed, they cried out to God.

But when they became secure and prosperous, they were tempted to say:

“My power and the might of my hand have gotten me this wealth.”

—Deuteronomy 8:17

I wonder: Has America fallen into the same trap?

The wilderness taught Israel, “*We need God.*”

Prosperity tempted them to believe, “*I can manage without Him.*”

That is the danger Moses wanted Israel to understand before they ever entered the land of promise.

The Pattern Repeated in Judges

The book of Judges provides a living demonstration of the same principle.

Israel repeatedly turned away from God. God allowed them to experience oppression. Eventually they cried out to Him. God raised up a deliverer. The people experienced peace again.

And then, after experiencing peace and blessing, they turned away once more.

The cycle repeated:

Rebellion → oppression → repentance → deliverance → peace → prosperity → forgetfulness → rebellion.

This does not mean that every Israelite followed the pattern, nor does it mean that suffering automatically produces righteousness. But the recurring pattern is difficult to miss.

There is something particularly sobering about the fact that Israel's spiritual failures often flourished not when they were being crushed by their enemies, but when they were enjoying the blessings God had given them.

They could survive the wilderness and still lose their way in the Promised Land.

When Comfort Becomes a Spiritual Danger

We tend to think of persecution as one of Christianity's greatest threats.

It certainly can be. Persecution can destroy lives, separate families, imprison believers, close churches, and even result in death. Christians should never minimize its terrible cost.

Yet persecution also forces a person to answer a question that comfort can allow us to avoid:

Is Christ worth the cost?

If following Christ means losing a job, reputation, freedom, family relationships, or even life itself, Christianity cannot remain merely a cultural preference. The believer must decide whether Christ is worth more than everything the world can take away.

Comfort presents a different challenge.

A Christian living in a society where Christianity is respected may never have to make difficult choices about his faith. He can attend church, sing hymns, carry a Bible, and identify himself as a Christian without ever having to ask what following Christ actually costs him.

Christianity can become part of the culture rather than the center of the life.

And that is a subtle danger.

This is perhaps my greatest fear for the church in America: Has cultural Christianity supplanted a true relationship with our Lord and Savior?

The Persecuted Church

This helps us understand something remarkable about Christians living under persecution today.

In places where Christianity carries a genuine cost, believers often demonstrate extraordinary courage and commitment. They may meet secretly, risk imprisonment, lose employment, be rejected by their families, or possess very little materially.

And yet they continue to worship Christ.

We should never romanticize their suffering. We should pray for their protection and freedom. Persecution is painful and destructive.

But we should learn from their example.

When the world takes away everything else, the believer discovers whether Christ is enough.

The persecuted Christian may possess very little and yet have a profound awareness of spiritual riches. Meanwhile, the prosperous Christian may possess almost everything and slowly lose the awareness that he needs God.

That is the paradox.

The Deceitfulness of Riches

Jesus warned about this very thing.

In the parable of the sower, He described the seed being choked by “the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches” (Matthew 13:22).

Notice that Jesus called riches *deceitful*.

Why?

Because riches can tell us something that is not true.

They can tell us:

You are secure.

You have enough.

You can solve your problems.

You don't need to worry.

You don't need to depend upon anyone.

And eventually:

You don't really need God.

Materialism does not necessarily tell us to hate God. It can be much more subtle. It can simply give us enough distractions that we gradually stop thinking about Him.

We don't necessarily reject God.

We become too busy for Him.

We don't deny His existence.

We compartmentalize Him.

God gets Sunday morning while the rest of our lives belong to us.

When God Becomes a Compartment

This may be one of the greatest dangers facing affluent Christianity.

We can have God and possessions.

God and careers.

God and entertainment.

God and family.

God and financial security.

But God was never intended to occupy one compartment of our lives.

He is supposed to be Lord of the whole life.

The danger of prosperity is that it allows us to construct a life in which we can function for long periods of time without consciously depending upon God.

Technology solves problems.

Money provides options.

Insurance provides security.

Medicine provides solutions.

Government provides services.

Transportation provides mobility.

Entertainment fills our empty moments.

None of these things is inherently wrong. In fact, many are tremendous blessings.

But together they can create an illusion of self-sufficiency.

We still believe in God. We simply don't *need* Him very much in our daily experience—or at least we don't think we do.

That is how a blessing can become a curse.

The Never-Ending Hunger for More

Have you ever noticed the strange contradiction in material prosperity? The more we have, the more we seem to want.

The sports-car enthusiast buys the latest Corvette, only to discover that a newer, faster model has now appeared. The house we once dreamed of owning eventually seems outdated and needs remodeling. The newest phone, television, computer, or other possession quickly gives way to something newer, faster, or better.

There is always another model.

Another upgrade.

Another improvement.

Another thing we are told we need.

This is the nature of materialism: *it never truly satisfies*. It promises satisfaction, but satisfaction always seems to be just one purchase away.

The newest becomes old. The fastest becomes ordinary. What once seemed extraordinary eventually becomes merely familiar.

And so, we pursue the next thing.

The problem isn't simply that we possess things. It is that things can train our hearts to believe that *the next thing* will finally make us satisfied.

But it never does.

Solomon discovered this long before the modern marketplace. He accumulated wealth, possessions, houses, gardens, servants, entertainment, and earthly pleasures, yet ultimately recognized the emptiness of pursuing life “under the sun” apart from God.

The human heart was never designed to find its ultimate satisfaction in created things.

We can always have more, but *more is not the same as lasting satisfaction*.

The Warning of Jesus to Laodicea

This brings us to one of the most sobering passages in the New Testament.

Jesus spoke to the church at Laodicea:

“For you say, I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing.”

Then comes the devastating response:

“not realizing that you are wretched, pitiable, poor, blind, and naked.”

—Revelation 3:17

Think about the contrast.

The church said:

“I am rich.”

Jesus said:

“You are poor.”

The church said:

“I have prospered.”

Jesus said:

“You are wretched.”

The church said:

“I need nothing.”

Jesus revealed that they desperately needed Him.

Laodicea is not described as a church suffering under persecution. It is a church that has become comfortable and has confused material prosperity with spiritual prosperity.

Whether we understand Laodicea as specifically representing the final stage of church history or simply as a warning applicable to every generation, the message is unmistakable:

A church can be materially successful and spiritually impoverished.

It can have resources without dependence.

Buildings without brokenness.

Programs without power.

Affluence without spiritual riches.

Religious activity without genuine hunger for God.

That is a frightening possibility.

From the Wilderness to Laodicea

There is therefore a remarkable biblical progression:

The wilderness teaches dependence.

The Promised Land introduces abundance.

Abundance creates the temptation to forget.

Forgetfulness produces self-sufficiency.

Self-sufficiency produces spiritual decline.

Laodicea becomes the picture of people who believe they need nothing while being desperately in need of Christ.

The connection between Deuteronomy 8, Judges, the teachings of Jesus, and Revelation 3 is worth taking seriously.

The warning given to Israel in the wilderness did not disappear when the New Testament church was established.

The human heart has not changed.

Suffering Can Produce What Comfort Often Does Not

The early church understood suffering differently from the way we often do.

James wrote:

“Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds.”

Why?

Because:

“the testing of your faith produces steadfastness.”

Paul likewise wrote that suffering produces endurance, endurance produces character, and character produces hope (Romans 5:3–4).

Peter spoke of faith being tested like gold in a fire.

The point was never that suffering is pleasant.

The point is that suffering can accomplish something comfort often cannot.

Trials reveal us.

They strip away illusions.

They expose false securities.

They teach us to pray.

They teach us to trust.

They teach us that we are not nearly as self-sufficient as we imagined.

And sometimes that is precisely what God wants us to discover.

We Should Not Seek Persecution—or Reject Prosperity

There is an important balance here.

The answer is not to conclude that persecution is good and prosperity is bad.

Scripture does not teach that.

We should be thankful for freedom, peace, food, homes, medicine, families, jobs, and material provision.

Nor should Christians seek poverty simply for the sake of becoming poor.

The issue is not what is in our hands.

The issue is what has happened to our hearts.

A wealthy Christian who recognizes that everything belongs to God is in a very different spiritual condition from a wealthy Christian who believes everything belongs to himself.

A comfortable Christian who uses his resources to serve others is different from one who uses them entirely for himself.

A free Christian who uses his freedom to proclaim Christ is different from one who uses his freedom merely to pursue comfort.

The biblical goal is not less blessing.

It is greater dependence.

Can We Remain Faithful When We Have Everything?

We often think the great test of faith is whether we can remain faithful when everything is taken away.

That certainly is a test.

But perhaps another test is whether we remain faithful when everything has been given to us.

Can we worship God when we are poor?

Yes.

But can we worship Him when we are rich?

Can we trust Him when we are sick?

Yes.

But can we trust Him when we are healthy?

Can we pray when we are desperate?

Yes.

But can we pray when we have everything we need?

Can we remain dependent upon God when we have money in the bank, food in the pantry, a comfortable home, reliable transportation, good health, and a secure future?

That may be a harder question than we want to admit.

The Western Church

This raises difficult questions about the decline of Christianity in much of Europe and substantial portions of North America.

We should not reduce that decline to a single cause. Secularism, cultural change, theological liberalism, family breakdown, political movements, institutional failures, changing demographics, and many other factors have contributed.

But perhaps we should also ask a more uncomfortable question:

Has prosperity itself contributed to our spiritual decline?

What if Christianity became so comfortable in the West that many people inherited Christian culture without developing Christian conviction?

What if the church became so familiar with Christianity that people no longer felt the urgency of the gospel?

What if freedom from persecution removed one of the pressures that once forced Christians to take discipleship seriously?

What if we have mistaken *Christian civilization* for *Christian faith*?

These are uncomfortable questions, but they are biblical questions.

The answer is not to desire persecution.

It is to recover the dependence upon God that persecution so often produces.

Remember the Wilderness

Perhaps the message the modern church needs to recover is the message Moses gave Israel:

Remember.

Remember where you came from.

Remember who provided for you.

Remember who sustained you.

Remember who delivered you.

Remember who gave you what you possess.

Remember that the house you live in, the food you eat, the money you earn, the health you enjoy, and the freedom you possess are gifts—not evidence of your independence.

And most importantly:

Do not allow God's blessings to become substitutes for God Himself.

Israel needed to remember the wilderness when they entered the Promised Land.

The church needs to remember the same principle.

A Different Kind of Revival

Perhaps the church does not merely need revival from persecution.

Perhaps it needs revival from prosperity.

Perhaps we need to rediscover what it means to hunger for God when we are not hungry for anything else.

To pray when we are not desperate.

To worship when everything is going well.

To seek God's kingdom when we already have comfortable lives.

To give when we have plenty.

To serve when we could simply entertain ourselves.

To open the Bible when there are a thousand other things competing for our attention.

To remember that Christianity is not merely something we *believe*.

It is Someone we *follow*.

When the Blessing Becomes the Curse

The wilderness and the Promised Land present two very different environments.

The wilderness says:

“You need God.”

Prosperity whispers:

“You have enough.”

Persecution asks:

“Is Christ worth the cost?”

Comfort asks:

“Do you really need Him?”

That may be one of the great tests facing the modern Western church:

Can we remain faithful when we have everything the world tells us we need?

The deeper problem is that no earthly possession can satisfy the place in the human heart that belongs to God. Blaise Pascal expressed this idea in his description of the restless human heart—a longing that earthly things cannot satisfy. His famous passage describes an “infinite abyss” that can be filled only by an infinite and immutable object—God Himself.

We can have wealth, health, security, freedom, comfort, possessions, and success, yet still remain spiritually empty.

There is no substitute for knowing Jesus.

We were created to know Him, trust Him, depend upon Him, and find in Christ the treasure that no amount of earthly prosperity can replace.

God's blessings are good. But when the blessing becomes more precious to us than the One who gave it, the blessing has become a curse.